



TAMIL NADU INDIA

Tasty Thali in Tamil Nadu

The southern Indian region of Tamil Nadu is a rich tapestry of soaring temple gateways, vivid green rice paddies, and towns abuzz with rickshaws, bullock carts, bicycles, and bustling humanity. As the majority of the devout population foregoes meat for religious reasons, the meal that keeps the Tamils going during a hard-working day is the unlimited vegetarian buffet known as the thali.



The practice of Hinduism has continued unbroken for millennia in Tamil Nadu, predating even the Vedas, the Hindu religion's oldest sacred texts. Some of the splendid temples with towering tapered gateways that dominate the towns of the region are over 1,000 years old. Tamil Nadu was one of the few places in India not to have been taken over by Mughal invaders during the 16th and 17th centuries, so the Tamils proudly claim to have preserved the purest form of Hinduism.

Consequently, Hindu beliefs pervade every part of everyday life. The dusty streets are full of shops nestled beneath temple towers selling brightly colored icons of deities, Shiva tridents, and the garlands of vibrant marigolds that are used to bring blessings to temples, homes, offices, and even cars and bicycles. In the country, trees guard shrines at their bases, while farmers in white dhotis plow fields using oxen – it all seems timeless, until a farmer whips out his cell phone. This is 21st-century India, and he'll probably be arranging where to meet his friends for a lunchtime thali, a small feast of a meal that has remained remarkably unchanged over the centuries; it is known in southern India simply as “meals.”

Thali can be enjoyed by visitors in one of the ubiquitous hole-in-the-wall restaurants, inside one of the newer chains of eateries, and at some hotels. Each diner is served a pile of rice in the middle of a banana leaf, which is then surrounded by at least half a dozen small metal bowls containing various side dishes. Occasionally these are ladled straight onto the rice, but either way, waiters continually replenish your meal until you beg for mercy. The accompanying dishes can be almost anything. There are always various vegetable or potato curries and the ever-present trio of sauces – spicy lentil and tomato *sambar*; thick, chili-pepper-and tamarind-based *vathal kozhambu*; and soupy *rasam*, a *dhal*-based thin sauce with a peppery tang. A *papad* (poppadom) and some lime pickle are usually thrown into the mix, along with palate-cooling curd and sometimes a sweet dish, such as rice pudding.

It can take outsiders a while to develop the knack of scooping up the messy food using just their right hand, but the trick is to copy the locals and press the mixture of rice and vegetables into a slightly firmer shape with your fingers before lifting it to your mouth. Eating off a neatly cut banana leaf is a novelty for most of us, but like so many other special things in Tamil Nadu, here it's just an everyday occurrence.

Three Days in Tamil Nadu

Tamil Nadu covers a vast area stretching from the Bay of Bengal coastline to the richly forested mountains of the Western Ghats. The northeastern part of the state, closest to the capital, Chennai, offers an excellent introduction to this cultural wonderland.

DAY ONE Leave the choking chaos of **Chennai** immediately by taking a prepaid taxi from the airport to the delightful seaside town of **Mamallapuram**. Take in the sea breeze beside the iconic shore temples, before strolling through the village past the **Arjuna's Penance** bas-relief and on to the “five shrines” **Pancha Rathas** monument.

DAY TWO Take a bus via Chengalpattu to **Tiruvannamalai**, famous for the atmospheric **Annamalaiyar** temple and the reddish-colored **Mount Arunachal**, where the revered guru Ramana Maharishi lived in a cave during the 20th century.

DAY THREE Connect by train to **Chidambaram**, which is centered on the enormous and imposing **Nataraja temple**, home to the special *dikshitar* caste of priests and the holy image of Shiva dancing in the eternal wheel of fire.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

Chennai has an **international airport** and a comprehensive **bus** and train **network**.

WHERE TO STAY

Mansoor Lodge (inexpensive) in Chidambaram is a very simple lodge conveniently located right opposite the temple. +91 4144 221 072

Greenwoods Resort (moderate) is a friendly family-run hotel in Mamallapuram near the beach. +91 44 2744 2251

Sparsa Resort (expensive) offers luxury in Tiruvannamalai. www.sparsaresorts.com

TOURIST INFORMATION

www.tamilnadutourism.org

